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TAKING A STANCE

MY NAME is Sahibzada Mohammad Shahid Khan Afridi. It's a long name and I'm proud of it.

The records say I was born on 1 March. That makes me a Piscean, although I think I am Sagittarian. But I don't believe much in such things, so I wouldn't know. No reason, really. I don't believe I know the future. Unlike many others, I don't like predicting my own future either. I like taking things one ball at a time.

I don't have many memories of my international debut in Nairobi in 1996, where I smashed that century for the record books in just my second ODI, the fastest the world had seen. But I remember being young, weightless and peerless as one feels at that age. I remember being carefree as I stepped on to the field with the very men I had revered as a kid, the cricket gods of that era. I also remember not being able to sleep much the night before that match. I remember a dream where I was hitting the big shots against the best in the world. And then I remember crowds rejoicing. Everywhere.

It is said that I 'changed the game' after that century but, honestly, the game changed me as well. In the public eye, I became someone else – not necessarily someone I had wanted to become.

I may have changed the game and let the game change me, but everything remained the same at home. I have six brothers and five sisters. I'm number five in the 11-member cricket team that is my family. I was four or five when I played cricket for the first time. I can't remember which habit I picked up first, bowling or batting. But I remember playing hard and fast.

My name is Shahid Afridi. I've represented the Pakistan cricket team for over twenty years in some of the toughest times in my great country's history. I've broken records, bats and hearts in the greatest game ever played. It might hurt some and it might not be what everyone would want to read, but here in these pages is my story. I only wish my father and mother – whom I dedicate these words to – were alive to read it.